

Session 9

Critical Role and long-form narrative. Unit 3: Practice.

DATE	TIME	LENGTH	ROOM	SECTION
Monday 21 September 2026	10:00 AM to 12:50 PM	170 minutes	SCI L104	18432

BEFORE YOU WALK IN

what is actually sitting on top of this class

9:00 AM	USC Games Faculty & Staff, Zoom Gini Benson's weekly. Ends 10:00.	CLASH
9:00 AM	USC Dept call Your own entry, ends 9:50.	
10:00 AM	CTIN 290 Session 9, SCI L104 170 minutes. This document.	NOW
10:00 AM	Gordon / Alex, Google Meet Recurring hold on the GGP calendar. NOT happening today. Gordon confirmed.	NOT TODAY
2:00 PM	Jeff McClusky, Festival University Introduced by Travis Laurendine. 15 colleges, 8 festivals.	
3:00 PM	Remy Routh Moved from 2:00 when McClusky landed.	

One real collision, and one ghost

Gini Benson's faculty meeting ends at 10:00 and class starts at 10:00. You cannot be on Zoom at 9:59 and in SCI L104 at 10:00. Leave the Zoom at 9:45 or accept that Session 9 opens at 10:10, which costs you the opening block.

"Gordon / Alex", 10:00 to 12:00, is not happening today. Gordon said so directly, and he is the source that counts on his own morning. It is a standing recurring hold that Alex owns, it still prints on the GGP calendar every Monday, and it is invisible next to CTIN 290 on the main one, which is exactly how it got into the first draft of this page. Kill the recurrence or decline the series, or the next person who reads this calendar, machine or human, makes the same mistake again.

THREE OBJECTIVES, RANKED

if you ran out of time, cut from the bottom

- 1

Name a visual signature and point at the frames that carry it.
Costume, posture, gesture, and the way those choices persist across hours of performance. This is the exact skill the Visual Analysis video is graded on and it is due Thursday, so if only one thing survives the morning, this is it.

DO NOT CUT
- 2

Say out loud what a cut costs.
In a theater your eye chooses and you can watch the person who is not speaking. On a screen somebody chose for you. Name the gain, close-ups no seat could buy, then name the loss. This is the first appearance of Adaptation, which you name properly in Session 12.

PROTECT IT
- 3

Put three terms in their hands: blocking, gesturality, reaction shot.
Each one gets seen on screen before it gets defined. The exit ticket tells you whether they actually landed.

RECOVERABLE

Where the slack went, and where what is left of it lives

The 59 minute Synthesis block is gone. It was by far the longest block and the only one with real give, and you spent it: 20 minutes of peer sharing, then 39 minutes of mood board team time. The trailer block at 11:16 is untouched and stays at thirty minutes.

Why that block is worth the whole back of the class. Sessions 10, 11 and 12 carry no team time of any kind. Checked against the teaching plan, not assumed. This is the only hour these four teams get in a room with you before the file is due Thursday 1 October, and the next time you are all together is the presentation itself on Monday 5 October. A team that leaves today without a decision written down loses a week, and you will not see it happen.

So the only give left is the 36 minute Critical Role block. If you are behind at 11:46, shorten the peer sharing to ten and protect the team time. Do not take it out of the trailer, which is doing two jobs, and do not take it out of the team block, which cannot be made up anywhere else on the calendar.

THE RUN SHEET

wall clock, because elapsed minutes are useless while teaching

10:00 AM	Opening
10:12 AM	Introduce Critical Role as long-form visual and narrative practice. 450+ hours of performance. Focus: how do actors establish character visually? Costume, movement, voice.
12 MIN	

10:12 AM 10:48 AM 36 MIN	Character Establishment Watch CR opening 30 min. Identify each character's introduction. What visual/physical choices define them? Costume? Posture? Gesture? How do these choices persist?
10:48 AM 11:06 AM 18 MIN	Activity Character Annotation: Students pick one CR character. Describe their visual signature. Costume details. Recurring gestures. Physical habits.
11:06 AM 11:16 AM 10 MIN	Ten-Minute Break The block is 170 minutes now, not 110. One five-minute break was enough for a two-hour class and it is not enough for this one. Take the full ten and leave the room, because the back half is the half that has to land.
11:16 AM 11:46 AM 30 MIN	Second Text, Hamilton, and the Camera as the Thing You Lost Critical Role gives you performance with an unmoving camera and four hours to breathe. Hamilton is a stage show crossed onto a screen, and the trailer is where the cost of that crossing becomes visible. In a theater your eye chooses, and you can watch the person who is not speaking. On a screen somebody chose for you. Ask what that gains, because it does gain something real: close-ups no seat in the house could ever buy. Then ask what it costs. This is the first appearance of the Adaptation through-line you name properly in Session 12, and it lands harder here, straight after an hour of watching performance with no director's eye in the way.
11:46 AM 12:06 PM 20 MIN	Synthesis, compressed Peer sharing only, and hold it to the one question that carries the grade: what visual choices define this character, and where did you see them persist. This ran 59 minutes on the original sheet. It is 20 now because the back of the class was given to the mood board, so do not let it wander into a general discussion. NO HOMEWORK IS SET TONIGHT. The old sheet asked for an hour of Critical Role and an annotation; it is cut. Their evening belongs to the Visual Analysis Video, due Thursday at 5:00. Say that plainly, because a room braced for an assignment that never arrives works harder on the one it already has.
12:06 PM 12:45 PM 39 MIN	MOOD BOARD TEAM TIME, team set 1 The only in-class work time this project gets. Sessions 10, 11 and 12 have no team block, so the next time these four teams are in a room together with you is the presentation itself. Rotate on a clock, four teams, about ten minutes each, and start with a different team than you would instinctively start with. With each team do three things, the same three you do in every Team Project Time: look at the actual board as it stands rather than a description of it, name the single most likely reason this misses Thursday 1 Oct, and agree one thing that will be true by Wednesday. Two questions that are specific to this assignment: say your palette out loud, and show me the one image on here you cannot justify. The second question finds the problem every time.
12:45 PM 12:50 PM 5 MIN	Exit Ticket, Two Lines Before Anyone Leaves One term you learned today and where you saw it. One thing you are still unsure of. Collect them at the door. This costs five minutes and it is the cheapest instrument you have for finding out what actually landed. The two things students are least likely to volunteer are which concept went past them and what they believe is expected of them, and this asks for both directly. Read them before the next session and open with the most common confusion, by name, so the room learns that saying you are lost actually changes what happens.

SAY THESE FOUR THINGS OUT LOUD

• At 10:00, "Four hundred and fifty hours of performance, one camera that barely moves. By noon you will be able to tell these people apart with the sound off." • At 11:16, opening Hamilton. "In a theater your eye chooses. On a screen somebody chose for you. What did that buy, and what did it cost?" • Whenever you name a term. Show it on screen first, define it second. All three of today's terms are visible before they are words. • At 12:45, collecting the exit tickets. "One term and where you saw it. One thing you are still unsure of. The second line is the one I actually need."
--

TODAY'S THREE TERMS

seen before defined, one question each

Blocking	
DEFINITION The choreography of character and camera movement within a scene; physical positioning and trajectory.	WHAT TO LOOK AT Bodies at a table. Who leans in, who pulls back, and when.
WHERE YOU SEE IT Sample any 10 min https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbym0pGX0	ASK THE ROOM Who moved last, and what did that movement tell you before anybody spoke?

Gesturality

DEFINITION

The expressive quality of movement; how characters move and what that movement communicates about state, intent, or personality.

WHAT TO LOOK AT

One performer, many selves, distinguished almost entirely by how they move.

WHERE YOU SEE IT

Throughout, 2:26

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wxN1T1uxQ2g>

ASK THE ROOM

If you muted this, how many of these people could you still tell apart?

Reaction Shot

DEFINITION

A shot of a character responding to action; often cut in for emotional emphasis or continuity.

WHAT TO LOOK AT

The table's faces are the story as often as the speaker is.

WHERE YOU SEE IT

Sample any 10 min

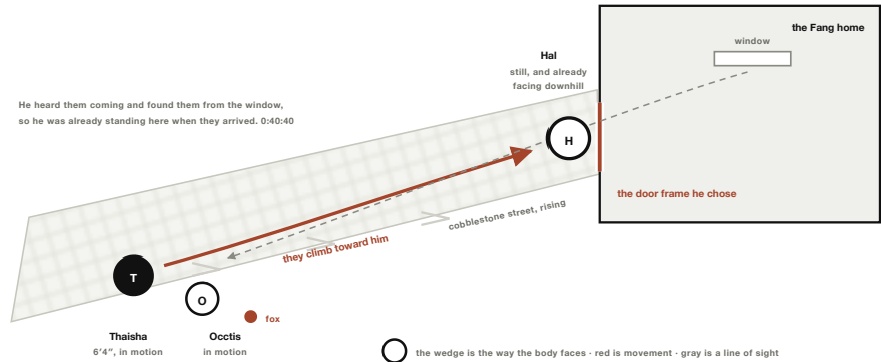
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbym0pGX0>

ASK THE ROOM

Whose face is the story right now, and is it the person talking?

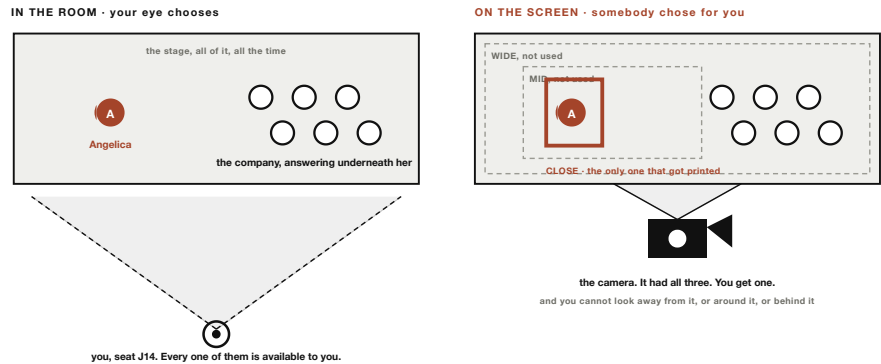
Both of today's clips block a scene in a way you can point at. Draw these on the board before you play the tape, or put this page under the document camera. The rule the diagrams teach: **blocking is position plus trajectory**, and it is doing work before anybody speaks.

A. Critical Role, 0:37:31 to 0:40:52. Nobody is on a screen here. The Game Master says a floor plan out loud and four players stand on it.



What the drawing gets you. Two characters move, one does not, and the one who does not move is the one who chose his position. Liam blocks Hal into the doorway out loud at 0:40:40 : "he heard conversation coming up the cobbled streets and spotted them out the window, so by the time you arrive at the door, Hal is leaning against the frame, just smiling at you as you approach." Ask the room: **who picked that spot, and what does standing there say that a line of dialogue would have had to say?**

B. Hamilton, 0:27 to 0:41. Same stage, two different machines deciding what you look at.



What the drawing gets you. At 0:27 Angelica sings "To your Union!" and the company answers her in the same bars, in parentheses, underneath. **Two things happen at once and only one of them can be the close-up.** In the house you decide, in real time, whether to watch her or watch them. On the Disney+ cut, the edit already decided, and you cannot undo it. That is the whole 11:16 argument in one 14-second stretch of tape. The gain is real: seat J14 never gets her face that size. Name the gain first, then the loss.

MEDIA, IN PLAY ORDER

DO NOT
OPEN

Critical Role Campaign 4 (Aramán), Opening Episode

Study character introduction and establishment. Notice costume, blocking, voice, and environment. How do they work together?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uo9z2glUmUo> · 1:26 long · First 30 minutes

10:12 AM

Critical Role Campaign 4, Key Character Moments

Official, Critical Role. Examine how performance and visual choices establish personality and relationships over long narrative.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbyn0pGX0> · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 minutes

DO NOT
OPEN

Critical Role Campaign 4, Action Sequences

Study how visual chaos is managed. Cutting, focus, character tracking in ensemble action.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Uo9z2glUmUo> · 1:26 long · Combat moments (variable)

11:16 AM	Hamilton, Official Trailer (Disney+) Official, Disney. A live stage show shot for a camera, cut from several performances plus a dedicated camera session on a closed stage. That is exactly the problem Critical Role solves every week and the problem your engine camera solves too: where do you put the lens when the performance was not staged for one. Watch blocking, watch where a cut steals your choice of what to look at, and watch how much a reaction shot changes a line you have already heard. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DSCkXPAGhc · 1:00 long · Throughout
10:12 AM	Blocking (glossary clip) Bodies at a table. Who leans in, who pulls back, and when. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbryn0pGX0 · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 min
ON DEMAND	Gesturality (glossary clip) One performer, many selves, distinguished almost entirely by how they move. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wxN1T1uxQ2g · 2:42 long · Throughout
10:12 AM	Reaction Shot (glossary clip) The table's faces are the story as often as the speaker is. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3Mbryn0pGX0 · 4 h 27 m long · Sample any 10 min

The 10:12 block cannot run as written, and this is the one thing to fix before you walk in

"Watch CR opening 30 min" points at a video that is 1 minute 26 seconds long. Uo9z2gIUuUo is a clip called *The Tables Converge*. Open it at 10:12 and you have eighty-six seconds and then thirty-four minutes of nothing in front of twelve people.

Play 3Mbryn0pGX0 instead. That is *The Fall of Thjazi Fang, Campaign 4, Episode 1*, four hours and twenty-seven minutes, the actual episode with the actual character introductions in it. Same official channel. Durations checked twice tonight, two different methods, same answers.

You do not have to scrub it. The numbers are below, pulled tonight off the episode's own caption track. The short version: the episode opens *cold and in character*, and the Game Master spends the first nineteen minutes asking his players, one at a time, to describe what their character looks like. Your 10:48 activity is performed by the cast, on camera, before the show's own title card.

And there is a trap inside "the first 30 minutes." At 0:18:51 the cold open ends and the show runs nine minutes of announcements and a sponsor sketch about wedding rings. Play 0:00 to 0:30 straight and you will be standing in front of twelve students watching Sam Riegel refuse to come out of his dressing room.

Hamilton is sixty seconds and the block is thirty minutes. That is not a problem, it is the shape of the block: play it three times. Cold. Again muted, so they watch only where the cuts land. Then a third time with the room calling each cut out loud. Ninety seconds of tape, twenty-eight minutes of argument.

Two smaller ones. "Action Sequences" is the same 1:26 clip under a different name, so there is no third Critical Role video. And the glossary calls 3Mbryn0pGX0 "Key Character Moments" and says "sample any 10 min" with no timestamp, which is a four and a half hour video; pick your ten minutes tonight, not at the podium.

Critical Role,		3Mbynm0pGX0	4 h 27 m · your 10:12 block	
IN	OUT	RUN	WHAT IS ON SCREEN	DO
0:00:00	0:18:51	18m 51s	The cold open, and the best eighteen minutes of teaching tape in this course. Brennan Lee Mulligan opens on Liam O'Brien: "someone you love very much is about to die. Could you please introduce us to your character?" Hal answers at 0:00:15 and describes himself: an older orc, dark hair streaked white, "fairly fine but not ostentatious clothing," smile lines at the eyes "from a life well lived." Brennan lays in the Guardian Wall and the gallows. At 0:04:59 he turns to Luis Carazo and Azune Nayar gets the same treatment: the braid, the birthmark up the right side of the face, eyes "like a sunset on an ocean."	PLAY
0:18:51	0:27:47	8m 56s	Announcements and the Thorum sponsor sketch. Fanfare, a bit about Sam Riegel refusing to leave his dressing room, a wedding-ring rap. Funny, and nine minutes of your class. The show itself calls it out: Sam complains at 0:21:11 that there is "this cold open now, before the best part of the show: my ads." The game returns on "welcome to Aramán" at 0:27:47.	SKIP
0:27:47	0:37:43	9m 56s	The world proper: Dol-Makjar, the stage, the square. Good, not essential. This is the first place to cut if you are behind.	SPARE
0:37:43	0:41:00	3m 17s	Two more introductions and one piece of blocking said out loud. "Aabria, would you please describe your character for us?" Thaisha Lloy at 0:37:46 : 6'4", an orc, desaturated green skin, silver irises ringed in red, fingers going red and black at the tips, wearing her family's colors, "the blood and the soot and scale of smiths." Occtis Tachonis at 0:39:17 : thin, dark noble clothing "clean but worn," implements on the belt, a book strapped to the leg, glassy-eyed, not blinking, a fox at his feet. Then at 0:40:40 Liam puts Hal in the doorway. That is diagram A.	PLAY

Total tape: 22 minutes and 8 seconds inside a 36-minute block, which leaves you fourteen minutes to talk, and it lands you on the annotation activity already warm. Play 0:00:00 to 0:18:51, then drag to 0:37:43.

Say this out loud, because it is the actual lesson. You cannot meet this cast in thirty minutes. Tyranny does not name herself until 1:21:49. Vaelus is introduced at 4:11:16, four hours in, in pure black. Character establishment in long-form is not a scene, it is a *schedule*, and that is precisely what separates it from the ninety-minute film they are comparing it against on Thursday.

Hamilton,		DSCKfXpAGhc	1:00 · your 11:16 block, played three times
AT	RUN	WHAT IS ON SCREEN	DO
0:04	11s	"Ladies and gentlemen, welcome to the show!"	An announcer, a house, a c
0:15	12s	John Laurens: "the ten-dollar Founding Father without a father."	One pe
0:27	14s	The fourteen seconds the whole block is built on.	Angelica sings "To yo
0:46	6s	"This... is Hamilton." Then the company sings "Alexander Hamilton" at 0:52.	

Everything Everywhere All At Once,		wxN1TluxQ2g	2:42, not 2:26 · the Gesturality clip
AT	RUN	WHAT IS ON SCREEN	DO
0:03	7s	"Mrs. Wang, are you with us?" Evelyn at the IRS desk, small, cornered,	
0:37	15s	Play exactly this for gesturality. The front door, same face, a different m	
0:56	12s	"I've seen thousands of Evelyns... you gonna access all their memories, the	
1:19	14s	"Don't make me fight you, I am really good!" / "I don't believe you." T	

Fix in the glossary while you are here: the Gesturality entry says 2:26. The video is 2:42, and the entry has no in point at all, which is what sent you to the whole trailer.

WHAT IS DUE, AND WHAT IS COMING

- **Thursday 24 September, 5:00 PM PT. Visual Analysis Video, 10%.** One world, two media, three to five minutes. Session 9 is the last Monday before it lands, and today's whole first hour is the skill it is graded on. Say the deadline out loud at 10:00 and again at 12:45.
- **No homework tonight, and say so out loud.** The old sheet set an hour of Critical Role and an annotation. **It is cut.** Their evening belongs to the **Visual Analysis Video, 10 percent, due Thursday at 5:00**, and an ungraded hour stacked on top of it would only have taught them which of your deadlines is the soft one. A room braced for an assignment that never arrives works harder on the one it already has.
- **The Critical Role work happens in this room, not at home.** The 10:12 block and the 10:48 annotation are the drill for **blocking, gesturality and reaction shot**, and the text is long-form because those three terms only exist across time: a two-minute clip cannot show a habit. That is why it is an episode and not a trailer, and it is why the drill does not need to follow anyone home.
- **Hamilton does both jobs, which is why sixty seconds of tape earns a thirty-minute block.** Your own media note on it names all three of today's terms: watch blocking, watch where a cut steals your choice of what to look at, and watch how much a reaction shot changes a line you have already heard. So the three plays at 11:16 **are** the vocabulary drill in a second register. Critical Role shows those terms with an unmoving camera and four hours to breathe; Hamilton shows the same three when somebody is cutting. That pairing is the reason both texts are in one session, and it is worth saying to the room in one sentence, because from the inside it just looks like two videos.
- **And the same thirty minutes is a worked example of their first assignment, performed.** *Hamilton* on stage and on screen is one of the four pairs the rubric approves by name, so when you run the 11:16 block you are not previewing the Visual Analysis Video, **you are doing one out loud**. Ask the rubric's three questions in the rubric's own words, in this order, and the mapping is exact: **what survived the crossing unchanged, what had to be reinvented because the new medium could not carry the original**, and **what is simply gone**. The third is the one that earns the top band and the one they will skip.
- **Why that is worth thirty minutes on a Monday.** Your own exit ticket exists because the two things students never volunteer are which concept went past them and **what they believe is expected of them**. A worked example answers the second one without anybody having to raise a hand, and it reaches the students who would never have asked. Every student in that room leaves knowing what a 5 sounds like, which is a different thing from having read the rubric. Say plainly that this is what the assignment looks like. Critical Role cannot serve there, because Campaign 4 exists in one medium and there is no second form to compare it against.
- **Mood board, and today it is not a footnote.** File due **Thursday 1 October**, presentations **Monday 5 October**, and the back of today's class belongs to it. The grading table that used to say 24 September was corrected in the Teacher's Guide overnight, so the documents now agree and nobody should be asking you which date is real. Say 1 October once at the top of the team block and move on.
- **Three worked examples exist, if you want them on the projector during team time.** gordonusc.github.io/the-cabinet/ctin290-mood-boards/ Three boards against your six words, each one labeled with why every image is on it, the palette measured from the actual pixels, and a set of in-game plates showing the HUD and the split screen rather than only the world. Student safe, no calendar and no names on it. Useful for the team that is stuck, and useful as a warning for the team whose board is twenty beautiful photographs and no screens.

WHAT THEY WERE ASKED TO DO BEFORE TODAY

from the syllabus, so you can ask for it

Sample ten minutes of Critical Role Campaign 4, Episode 1 before class. Rewatch Blocking, Gesturality and Reaction Shot afterwards.

Session 9 collects nothing and issues no graded work. Nothing is due at the door today, so the only thing you are chasing in the room is whether they watched.

ONE SPARE ACTIVITY, IF YOU FINISH EARLY

Sound off, five minutes

Play any ten minutes of 3Mbynm0pGX0 with the audio muted. Ask them to write down, without conferring, who is currently the most powerful person at that table and what told them. Then unmute and play the same ten minutes again.

It costs five minutes, it proves gesturality and reaction shot in one move, and it hands them a method they can use on Thursday's assignment tonight.

AFTER CLASS, TWO LINES

write them before you open the laptop

What paid for the extra minutes today?

What is the most common thing on the exit tickets, and how do you open Session 10 with it?

Session text, timing blocks and glossary entries are lifted verbatim from the CTIN 290 Fall 2026 Teacher's Guide, artifact ede331ff. Objectives, the ranking, the wall clock, the spare activity, the four spoken lines and the defect notes are Darby's and are marked as such. Every video verified live against the YouTube oEmbed endpoint on 20 September 2026, and every duration against the watch page's own lengthSeconds. The in and out points on this page were read on 21 September 2026 from each video's published caption track, which timestamps speech exactly; the quoted lines are verbatim from it. What the camera is doing in any given second is the one thing a caption cannot tell you, so the shot calls in the diagrams are arguments to make in the room, not claims about the edit. Calendar read from gbellamy@gmail.com and ggpcharity@gmail.com the same evening. Built for letter paper.